

and Order, K.L. Prasad says, "In cities like Mumbai, crime occurs because of the sheer economic disparity. The rich children have so much that they want to feel the thrill of experimenting. The poor, on the other hand, indulge in criminal acts in order to get out of their pathetic situation."

In all cases, however, the common cause for increased violence is the lack of adequate parental supervision. Experts attribute errant behaviour to parents spending lesser time with children. "Many parents try to make up for the lost time with money, hoping that the child will use the freedom and the money wisely. Children

Looking out for symptoms of delinquent behaviour, therefore, is an important step towards curbing potential criminal activities. And chronic depression, day-dreaming, not performing well in class despite being a bright student, overly mischievous or destructive behaviour and disobedience are common traits among children who resort to offen-

However, the causes and effects of the rise in juvenile delinquency is not the only debate worth paying heed to. The conflict in existing laws and the differences among the legal communities on the subject are other concerns that affect this growing trend. While one segment lobbies for the revision of the definition of a 'child,' another advises that certain cases of



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ANJALI CHHABRIA,
Psychiatrist

Signs of delinquency

- Anti-social behaviour like resorting to destruction of school or personal property
- Quiet or subdued behaviour from otherwise bright children
- Extremely mischievous behaviour tending to garner negative attention
- Daydreaming, extreme impulsiveness, depression
- Continued disobedience and scant regard for authority



What schools and parents can do

- Spend time with the child to explore his or her strengths
- Be patient with children suffering from learning disabilities
- Put emphasis on physical activities and sports for at least a few hours daily.
- Enlist the services of counselors to guide and help the child if he or she is distressed

SAURABH SINGH



“By observing their parents, children realise that there is a way to work their way around the law.”

HARISH SHETTY,
Psychiatrist

vent the pent-up anger against their current situation,” explains Shetty.

Another reason behind the rise of juvenile crime is that delinquent behaviour is often not spotted or nipped in the bud, especially in schools. “Many children suffer from Attention Deficit Disorders and Learning Disabilities. They get singled out in classrooms. They get frustrated and indulge in acts that earn them negative attention,” says Anjali Chhabria, a Mumbai-based psychiatrist.

sive behaviour. Therefore, counselling systems in schools go a long way in helping to identify students displaying errant behaviour. While schools acknowledge the importance of the student-counsellor bond, the volumes of children involved make it difficult for teachers to establish a very good rapport with students. Says Chona: “We train all our teachers to handle the needs of a distressed child. Sometimes sheer volumes can hamper the process.”

juvenile delinquency deserve more stringent action from the authorities. Says Special Public Prosecutor Ujjwal Nikam, “The time has come to make a radical change in the Juvenile Justice Act, which is not deterrent but merely reformatory in nature. If children indulge in deliberate and well-planned criminal acts, they should be suitably punished and tried under the IPC. Knowing the inadequacy of our laws, terror groups may take advantage of the current situation and suspects may get away.”

As the debate continues on redefining the meaning of “juvenile crime”, it's time for society to introspect on the causes for the rise in aggression among children. ■